

A Friend AT NO. 10

The new Prime Minister is seen as a friend of India and the bilateral relationship is expected to grow stronger

| By Saurabh Shukla |

The Dictionary of British politics may soon have a new entry—'khichdi government'—as Britain ushered in a new Conservative Government led by David Cameron with the support of the Liberal Democrats, the first coalition government after a gap of more than three decades. In a parallel with Indian politics, the formation of the first non-Labour government in ten years was preceded by tense negotiations over power sharing and portfolios. Nick Clegg, the Liberal Democrat leader, will be Deputy Prime Minister but all eyes are on the charismatic Cameron. In South Block, the question being debated was whether a Conservative government would be good for India. It's a question worth asking. India and Britain share one of the strongest bilateral relationships in the international arena, apart from

the reality of the over 1.2 million Indians settled in the UK. Under Labour, with two economists at the helm of affairs, Gordon Brown and Manmohan Singh, the existing personal chemistry caused the bond to grow stronger.

While a new chemistry will have to be built between 7 Race Course road and 10 Downing Street, Cameron is seen as a friend of India and bilateral ties are expected to remain on an even keel. Manmohan was one of the first world leaders to telephone Cameron and congratulate him. "We need to strengthen the close relationship between our two countries," he told Cameron, and invited him to India, which was immediately accepted by the Prime Minister-designate. The 43-year-old former PR executive is not new to India. The Etonian who also studied at Oxford, made India his first overseas trip in 2006 after he became leader of the Conservatives. Driven by



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CAMERON MADE INDIA HIS FIRST FOREIGN HALT AFTER BECOMING TORY LEADER AND WANTS "A NEW SPECIAL RELATIONSHIP."

CAMERON AND CLEGG AFTER THE VICTORY; (BELOW LEFT) CAMERON WITH PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH

his personal conviction, the Tory election manifesto made a specific mention of forging "a new special relationship with India," and it is the strands of this new relationship that will form the basis of bilateral ties in the near future. Last year when Indian President Pratibha Patil paid a state visit to the UK, she held discussions with Cameron and Clegg and both stressed their personal commitment to the bilateral partnership. "It is a dynamic relationship, and under